

Skills Summary

Comparing Three-Digit Numbers

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Comparing with symbols

Rule: Compare place by place, starting with the biggest place.

- Hundreds first. More hundreds wins — stop there.
- Tie? Compare tens. Still tied? Compare ones.
- The open mouth of $<$ or $>$ always faces the bigger number.

Example: Write $<$, $>$, or $=$: compare 463 and 437.

Step 1. Compare hundreds first: both have four hundreds, so move to the tens.

Step 2. 463 has six tens and 437 has only three tens, so 463 is greater. $\Rightarrow$ **463 $>$ 437**

Try it: Write $<$, $>$, or $=$: compare 528 and 582.

check: 582 $>$ 528

(!) Watch out: Big tens or ones can never beat a hundreds difference. Always settle the hundreds *before* looking at anything else.

Skill 2 — Ordering several numbers

Rule: To put numbers in order, compare them two at a time. Find the least, write it first, then order what is left the same way.

Example: Order least to greatest: 341, 314, 431.

Step 1. Sort by hundreds first: 431 has four hundreds, so it is greatest; the other two tie at three hundreds.

Step 2. Break the tie with tens: 314 has one ten, 341 has four tens, so 314 comes first.
 $\Rightarrow$ **314, 341, 431**

Try it: Order least to greatest: 268, 286, 226.

check: 226, 268, 286

Skill 3 — Comparing in a story

Rule: In a word problem, first pull out the two quantities and their units, write the comparison with a symbol, then answer the question in words (*who* or *which one*).

Example: A young oak tree is 175 cm tall and a maple is 157 cm tall. Which tree is taller?

Step 1. Pull out the two heights and compare hundreds first: they tie at one hundred, so the tens decide.

Step 2. 175 cm has seven tens and 157 cm has five tens, so the oak is taller. $\Rightarrow$ **$175 > 157$** , so the oak is taller.

Try it: Ana scored 342 points and Ben scored 324 points. Compare with a symbol. Who scored more?

check: $342 > 324$ — Ana